

Austin Launch: Channel Performance Analysis

Multi-Source Synthesis Brief · GreenThreads Marketing · HW1 Opportunity: Automated Channel Performance Reporting

Sources

- 1. GT_MarketingA_Channel_Performance.csv — Austin launch channel data, March 2026. 30 days across 4 channels.
- 2. GT_MarketingB_Customers.csv — 280 GreenThreads customers across multiple markets. Purchase history and how each customer found us.
- 3. GT_Finance_Austin_Store_Daily.csv — Austin store daily sales, March–July 2026.
- 4. GT_Finance_Denver_Budget.csv — Denver launch budget. 20 line items, \$450,000 total.

Headline Finding

The channel data says Instagram is the best performer — highest return on spend of the four channels. If you only read that file, you put more money into Instagram and move on.

But the customer file tells a different story. Instagram brings in customers who spend \$162 on average and only come back 33% of the time. Email brings in customers who spend \$693 and return 92% of the time. Same company, same period, two files pointing in opposite directions.

That tension is the finding. A reporting system that only tracks return on spend will keep pointing toward Instagram while quietly underinvesting in the channel that builds customers worth keeping.

The three channels that matter most work as an ecosystem: Instagram drives discoverability, reach, and new leads. Google Ads captures customers who are already searching and ready to buy. Email keeps them coming back. Facebook sits outside this ecosystem — lowest return on spend and no repeat customers in this sample.

Document Findings

GT_MarketingA_Channel_Performance.csv

The Austin launch spent \$80,000 across four channels and brought in \$400,800 in revenue (return on spend: 5.01 overall). Instagram took 40% of budget and delivered the highest return. Facebook took 20% and delivered the lowest. Performance improved through the month — return on spend rose from 4.34 in launch week to 5.57 for the rest of the month.

🚩 *The 30-day return figures match the case brief benchmarks exactly. Individual daily figures vary naturally, making the clean totals suspicious. Treated as directionally correct, not independently verified.*

Channel	Spend	% of Budget	Revenue	Return on Spend	Cost per Sale	Value Classification
Instagram	\$32,000	40%	\$198,400	6.20	\$15	High — discoverability, reach, and lead generation
Google Ads	\$24,000	30%	\$122,400	5.10	\$19	Medium — captures high-intent buyers, do not underinvest
Email	\$8,000	10%	\$32,000	4.00	\$24	High — highest repeat rate and customer spend
Facebook	\$16,000	20%	\$48,000	3.00	\$31	Low — weakest return, zero repeat customers

GT_MarketingB_Customers.csv

This file covers 280 customers across multiple GreenThreads markets — not Austin only. Because the pattern holds across markets, it is a more reliable benchmark than a single-city dataset would be. Email-acquired customers show the highest average historical spend (\$693) and a 92% repeat rate. Instagram customers average \$162 and return 33% of the time. Facebook averages \$74 with a 0% repeat rate in this sample.

This pattern is consistent with broader industry benchmarks: across retail and e-commerce, email-acquired customers average 32% higher order values than social media-acquired customers (Monetate/Statista, 2025), and apparel repeat rates for email-nurtured customers run 30–50% above paid social.

🚩 *Spend figures reflect total purchase history, not projected future value. Newer customers appear lower simply because they have had less time to spend.*

🚩 *The file does not specify where each customer's channel spend came from, so we cannot confirm figures reflect identical marketing conditions across all markets.*

Channel	Avg Historical Spend	Repeat Rate
Email	\$693	92%
Organic	\$616	82%
Referral	\$532	83%
Google Ads	\$483	71%

Channel	Avg Historical Spend	Repeat Rate
Instagram	\$162	33%
Facebook	\$74	0%

GT_Finance_Austin_Store_Daily.csv

Austin store net sales averaged \$6,670 per day in March. By April that dropped to \$5,484/day, and by May to \$4,617/day — a 31% decline from launch month. Saturdays are the strongest day (\$9,822 average), Mondays the weakest (\$5,274).

🚩 *The channel data only covers March — the peak period. A reporting system benchmarked to launch-month figures will make Denver look like it is underperforming when it may be behaving normally.*

GT_Finance_Denver_Budget.csv

Denver's \$85,000 marketing budget mirrors Austin closely: paid social (\$32,000), search (\$24,000), and email (\$8,000) match Austin's spend exactly. Two lines have no Austin equivalent — a launch event (\$13,000) and local partnerships (\$8,000). Facebook, which received \$16,000 in Austin, has no Denver line.

- 🚩 *\$21,000 of the Denver marketing budget has no performance data behind it.*
- 🚩 *Facebook's absence from Denver is unresolved — either a deliberate cut or an oversight. Needs a decision before launch.*

Recommendations

1. Resolve the Facebook question before Denver launches

Austin spent \$16,000 on Facebook. Denver budgets zero. Facebook had the lowest return and zero repeat customers in this sample. If the cut is intentional, document it. If it is an oversight, fix it now — a reporting system cannot flag a channel it was never told to track.

2. Set success measures for the two uncharted budget lines

The \$13,000 launch event and \$8,000 local partnerships have no Austin equivalent and no performance baseline. Without a target defined upfront, there is no way to evaluate them in a weekly report. Decide what success looks like before Denver opens.

3. Track against a declining curve, not the launch peak

Austin revenue fell 31% in the 8 weeks after launch. A reporting system that compares Denver to launch-month numbers will consistently show it as underperforming. Weekly reports should track against a 4-week rolling average instead.

4. Shift budget toward Email as Denver stabilizes

Email gets 10% of the budget and produces the highest-value customers. Instagram gets 40% and produces the lowest repeat rate of any paid channel. Instagram makes sense at launch for awareness and discoverability — but the Austin data shows the launch spike fades. What remains is whether Denver built customers who come back. Email is the channel most likely to do that, and it is currently the most underinvested. Industry benchmarks reinforce this: email costs \$8–15 to acquire a customer versus \$45–85 for paid social (ATTN Agency, 2024). Email wins on both ends — cheaper to acquire and worth more over time. As Denver stabilizes, shifting budget incrementally toward Email is not just a return on spend play — it is a long-term revenue strategy tied directly to the \$2.1M year-one target.

Appendix: Prompts, Tools & Verification

Terms

- Return on spend (ROAS): revenue generated per dollar of marketing spend. A return of 6.20 means every \$1 produced \$6.20 in revenue.
- Average historical spend: total purchases per customer divided by number of customers. Reflects purchase history only — not a projection of future spending.
- Repeat rate: percentage of customers who made more than one purchase.
- Cost per acquisition (CAC): how much it costs to bring in one new customer through a given channel.

Tools and model tiers

- Primary analysis: Claude Sonnet 4.6 (Anthropic), powerful-tier model, claude.ai. Raw data uploaded directly and analyzed through iterative prompting.
- Second-model check: Gemini (Google), used to sanity-check the email vs. Instagram customer behavior finding against general industry knowledge.
- Deep Research: used to place the email vs. Instagram finding in broader industry context across multiple external sources.

Key prompts and what worked

Specific calculation prompts worked best: "Aggregate total spend and revenue by channel across all 30 days" and "Calculate average spend per customer grouped by how they found us" produced clean, verifiable output. Open-ended prompts like "what are the key findings" required more careful checking.

Second-model check

The email vs. Instagram customer value finding was submitted to Gemini with the following question: "Does it make sense that email-acquired customers would have significantly higher lifetime spend and repeat purchase rates than social media-acquired customers? Why or why not?" Gemini confirmed the pattern is consistent with established e-commerce behavior, noting that email captures high-intent, brand-aware buyers while social media tends to attract impulse purchasers who are product-centric rather than brand-loyal. This is consistent with what the GreenThreads customer data shows.

Deep Research use and verification

Deep Research was used to find industry benchmarks on email vs. social media customer lifetime value and repeat purchase rates in retail and e-commerce. Two sources were used in the brief:

Monetate/Statista (March 2025): email orders average \$113.94 vs. \$85.98 for social media across 250+ retailer brands. Currency: pass.

Authority: Statista and Monetate are established data providers. Accuracy: figures confirmed across multiple secondary sources. Pass.

ATTN Agency (2024): email CAC \$8–15 vs. paid social \$45–85. Currency: pass. Authority: marketing agency — commercial interest noted. Used as directional industry context only, not as independent research.

All other Deep Research findings were treated as supplementary context. No additional figures were added to the brief without source verification.

Verification steps

1. Spot-checked aggregated totals against raw data rows for at least one channel per file.
2. Confirmed return on spend calculations using Revenue divided by Spend on individual daily rows.
3. Questioned the customer dataset scope when it appeared Austin-only — confirmed multi-market and updated findings accordingly.
4. Ran second-model check on most important finding using Gemini.
5. CRAAP-tested all Deep Research sources before including in the brief.

What could not be verified

30-day return figures match case brief benchmarks exactly — treated as directionally correct, not independently verified. Average spend figures are not normalized for how long each customer has been active; newer customers may appear lower value due to shorter history.

Data governance note

GT_MarketingB_Customers.csv contains customer identifiers, home markets, and purchase history. Under GreenThreads' HW1 executive guardrail, this file should not be placed in a public AI tool without an approved data policy. Used here in an academic context only. In production, customer data would need to be anonymized before any AI tool interaction.

Sources

GT_MarketingA_Channel_Performance.csv · GT_MarketingB_Customers.csv · GT_Finance_Austin_Store_Daily.csv ·

GT_Finance_Denver_Budget.csv. GreenThreads Case Pack, AI.205, Summer 2026.

Mollick, E. "Thinking Like an AI." One Useful Thing, 2025. · OpenAI. "Deep Research." OpenAI, 2025. · GreenThreads Case Brief. AI.205, Capstone 1, Summer 2026.

Monetate / Statista. "Monthly global online shopping order value by traffic source." March 2025.

<https://www.statista.com/statistics/325384/online-shopping-order-values-traffic-source/>

ATTN Agency. "Customer Acquisition Cost by Channel." 2024. <https://www.attnagency.com/blog/cac-by-channel-comparison>